There was a boy on the beach. A Shompen boy. One of the ancient tribes that lived in the darkest forest. They were barely more than cave-people. They were ignorant in the ways of modern life. The Shompen still sacrificed animals, they stole from rubbish tips and they shot arrows at helicopters.

Give evidences to show what kind of people Shompens were.

3. The boy had a swipe of ebony hair hanging over one eye. The other was brown, wide and staring over my shoulder. 'Mountain wave,' he said in a



DO YOU KNOW? Shompens are primarily hunter-gatherers and also practise a little bit of horticulture and pig rearing.

gruff voice. 'Are you speaking to me?' I asked. Shompens were not known for their social skills. Generally, they stayed as far away from civilization as the island of Great Nicobar will allow, although in recent years ancient barriers were being worn down and there was even some trading between the Shompens and Nicobaric. But this was the first time in my life that a Shompen had addressed me. I tapped my chest. 'Me? Are you talking to me?' The boy pointed out to sea. 'First the earth shakes, then the mountain wave comes. We must go.' The boy spoke Car with a heavy accent. The Shompen have their own ancient language, but no one outside their tribe can speak it. No one can be bothered to try. `Go,' he repeated, gesturing towards the forest. 'Now.'

Why was the narrator surprised when the Shompen boy spoke to him?

4. My mother had always told me never to follow a Shompen anywhere, especially into the forest. And I did not intend to disobey her. Anyway, I wanted to watch the wave. It was really something when a big wave broke on the shore, cutting long furrows into the sand. I turned my back on the boy. Our conversation was over.The giant wave made me catch my breath. Suddenly it was close and huge. I hadn't realised how big it must be. Higher than the trees surely. And fast too. It seemed as though the entire ocean was coming this way, not just the surface.'What?' I said, in surprise, but my own words were smothered by the gigantic rumbling. I felt dwarfed. I felt a hand in my pocket, and it was not my own hand. A brown arm had snaked in around my waist. The Shompen boy was picking my pocket. 'Hey!' I objected, grabbing at the stick-thin arm. But it was gone, and so was my money pouch, packed with my birthday rupees.

"The giant wave made me catch my breath." Why did he say so?

5. The small Shompen boy darted between the palms on the edge of the beach. He would disappear now, I knew it, and I would never catch him. The Shompen were like ghosts in the jungle. But for some reason, the boy stopped. He turned and waved my pouch at me. A taunt that no thirteen-year-old boy could resist. That little thief may have been Shompen, but my legs were fast. I forgot the wave and ran. It was quite a chase. I could run, but the Shompen boy could read the jungle

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